



1

HIS ROLLS-ROYCE became an omnibus, bearing parties to and from the city...”, wrote F. Scott Fitzgerald, describing the opulence of Gatsby in his canonical piece *The Great Gatsby*.

Similarly, in a show of luxury and wealth, Udaipur turned sepia as vintage and classic cars rolled into the city for the second edition of The Oberoi Concours d’Elegance—a show where cars are displayed and judged on their appearance and restoration work. From pre-war European and

American cars to post-war classics, many of these cars have a storied history.

Take, for instance, billionaire Yohan Poonawalla’s Rolls-Royce Phantom 1, which was designed and built in 1928 by Henry Royce himself. The car, first bought by the Hari Singh, Maharaja of Kashmir, spent several years in the country before it left Indian shores in early 1970s.

“It changed several famous hands in Europe including Victor Muller. Then I happened to get my hands on it a couple of years back,”

Poonawalla tells *Business Today*.

This one-off car, also known as 17 EX (experimental), was built to beat Bentley at Le Mans and do the 100-mile-an-hour in those days, according to Poonawalla. Before the Second World War, India was one of the biggest markets for Rolls Royce.

“India accounted for one-fourth of Rolls-Royce’s total sales from 1912 to 1947. Maharajas saved Rolls-Royce during the war years. Indian royals would go to London and Paris shows and buy cars there. The Kashmir car was



2

1. 1935 Rolls-Royce Phantom II Drophead Coupé owned by Maharaja Gaj Singh of Jodhpur **2.** Arjun Oberoi, Executive Chairman, EIH, with Irene Nikkein, Regional Director Asia-Pacific, Rolls-Royce Motor Cars